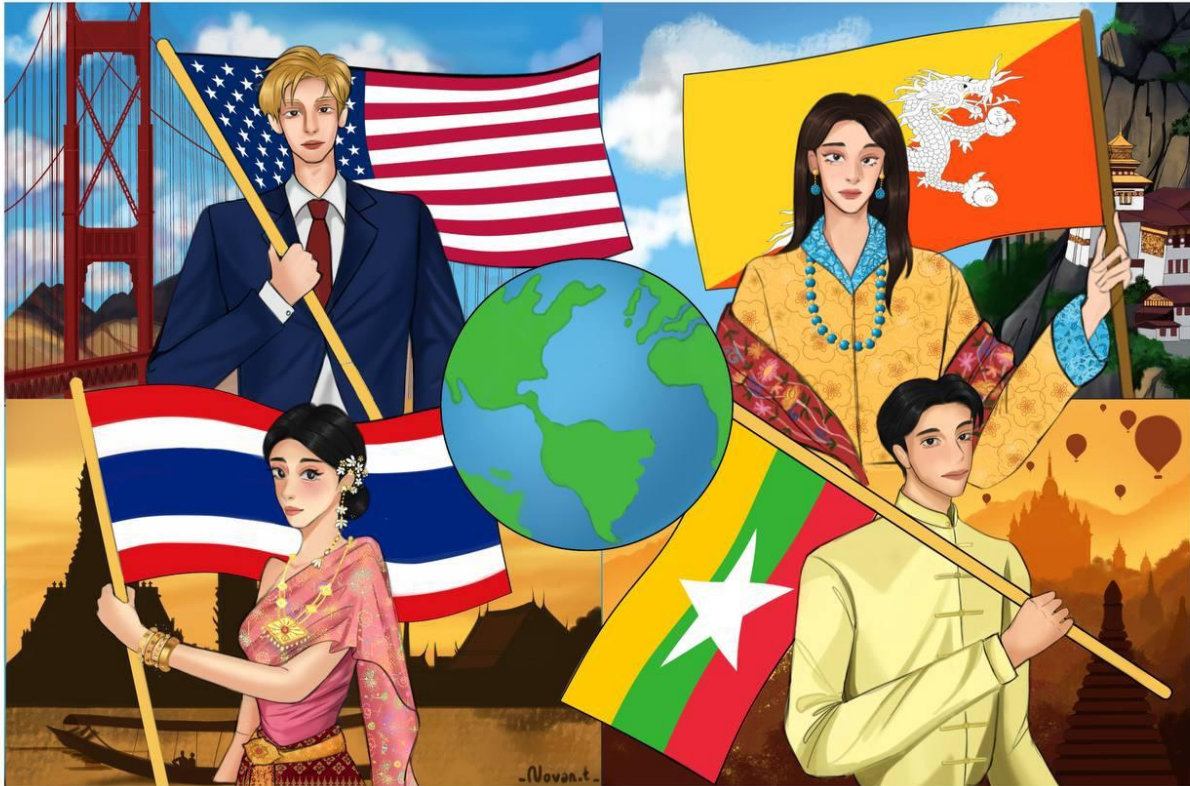


CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION TO INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION



UNDERSTANDING COMMUNICATION, CULTURE, AND INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION

Intercultural communication is now woven into the fabric of our daily lives. Thanks to globalization, people from all sorts of cultural backgrounds meet and interact more often than ever before¹. And these cross-cultural encounters are not just about people from different countries; they also happen among those shaped by different regions, religions, organizations, professions, or even different national cultures within the same country². To really grasp what intercultural communication means, we need to look at how we communicate, how culture shapes the meanings behind our words, and how the situations we're in influence every interaction.

¹ Young Yun Kim, "Intercultural Personhood: Globalization and a Way of Being," *International Journal of Intercultural Relations* 32, no. 4 (2008): 359–68, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijintrel.2008.04.005>.

² Ariane Berthoin Antal and Victor J. Friedman, "Learning To Negotiate Reality: A Strategy for Teaching Intercultural Competencies," *Journal of Management Education* 32, no. 3 (2008): 363–86, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1052562907308794>.

Communication and Meaning

Communication is all about sharing messages and ideas in ways that help us truly understand each other³. We communicate to get to know one another, build relationships, find common ground, and work together to solve problems⁴. But it is not just about passing along information. People interpret social interactions by making sense of verbal communication, vocal signals, and interpersonal behavior⁵.

The way someone understands a message is not always what the sender meant⁶. For example: a student writes, “Please send me your part of the assignment soon.” The student may imply it as a follow-up, but the person receiving it could see it as pushy or critical. Whether something comes across as polite or rude depends a lot on who is involved and the situation they are in⁷.

That’s why communication is a two-way street. Both speakers and listeners play a part in building meaning together; they give feedback, ask for clarification, repeat things, and rephrase when there is a misunderstanding⁸. Meaning does not just come from the sender; it grows out of how everyone interprets and responds.

People communicate through words and nonverbal signals. Verbal communication includes spoken and written language⁹. Gestures, posture, eye contact, and tone of voice can provide additional information about a message¹⁰. For example, the words “I am happy to help” may sound sincere when spoken warmly but unwilling when spoken in a cold tone. Because nonverbal behavior can have different meanings across cultures, listeners should consider the situation before deciding what a particular signal means.

Understanding Culture

Culture grows out of the way we interact with others and share habits and traditions. These habits (like values, expectations, norms, and the moral frameworks we follow) are how groups make

³ Lily A. Arasaratnam and Marya L. Doerfel, “Intercultural Communication Competence: Identifying Key Components from Multicultural Perspectives,” *International Journal of Intercultural Relations* 29, no. 2 (2005): 137–63, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijintrel.2004.04.001>.

⁴ Mark C. Hopson et al., “Meeting in the Middle: Fred L. Casmir’s Contributions to the Field of Intercultural Communication,” *International Journal of Intercultural Relations* 36, no. 6 (2012): 789–97, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijintrel.2012.08.008>.

⁵ Wolfgang Scholl, “The Socio-Emotional Basis of Human Interaction and Communication: How We Construct Our Social World,” *Social Science Information* 52, no. 1 (2013): 3–33, <https://doi.org/10.1177/0539018412466607>.

⁶ Antal and Friedman, “Learning To Negotiate Reality.”

⁷ Elizabeth Axelson, “Vocatives: A Double-Edged Strategy in Intercultural Discourse among Graduate Students,” *Pragmatics. Quarterly Publication of the International Pragmatics Association (IPra)* 17, no. 1 (2007): 95–122, <https://doi.org/10.1075/prag.17.1.04axe>.

⁸ Jesús Romero-Trillo and Elizabeth Lenn, “Do You ‘(Mis)Understand’ What I Mean? : Pragmatic Strategies to Avoid Cognitive Maladjustment,” *Journal of English Studies* 9 (May 2011): 223–41, <https://doi.org/10.18172/jes.173>.

⁹ Liangguang Huang and Runjiang Xu, “A Study of Culture Teaching in College English Teaching,” *Theory and Practice in Language Studies* 1, no. 6 (2011): 681–87, <https://doi.org/10.4304/tpls.1.6.681-687>.

¹⁰ Jan Hamilton and Robyn Woodward-Kron, “Developing Cultural Awareness and Intercultural Communication through Multimedia: A Case Study from Medicine and the Health Sciences,” *System* 38, no. 4 (2010): 560–68, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.system.2010.09.015>.

sense of the world together¹¹. Culture shapes the way we see situations, what we expect from those around us, and how we act¹².

Some parts of culture are easy to spot in the way people act, but much of it happens beneath the surface, hidden in the assumptions, norms, and values we might not even realize we hold¹³. For example, our beliefs about authority, family, gender roles, intentions, and how we show emotions can all be shaped by culture, even if we do not think about them¹⁴. Often, we only notice these things when we meet someone whose way of communicating is different from our own.

People learn about culture through family life, education, work, and participation in their communities. However, members of the same cultural group do not necessarily think or behave in the same way¹⁵. Each person belongs to a different combination of social groups, so important differences exist within every culture¹⁶. Cultural knowledge may suggest why a communication pattern occurs, but it cannot predict exactly how an individual will behave.

Culture is not set in stone, either. It keeps changing as people travel, move to new places, use new technologies, and meet others from different backgrounds¹⁷. We should not think of culture as something that never changes.

Culture is about much more than just nationality. Nationality is only one influence on cultural identity and belonging because individuals may also belong to kinship, ethnic, religious, political, economic, and recreational groups¹⁸. While cultural models can help us spot patterns, they can't explain every choice or behavior. People are complex, and the way they communicate does not always align with stereotypes or typical patterns in their home country¹⁹.

Intercultural Communication

Intercultural communication involves dialogue among people with culturally diverse identities as they work toward mutual understanding and shared meaning²⁰. It is not just about conversations between people from different countries; it can also occur between people with different religions, regions, languages, or other cultural influences²¹.

¹¹ Mircea Valeriu Deaca, "Extended Control Cycle in Ritual Behavior and Narrative Scenarios," *Transylvanian Review* 30, no. 3 (2021): 121–49, <https://doi.org/10.33993/TR.2021.3.08>.

¹² Antal and Friedman, "Learning To Negotiate Reality."

¹³ Antal and Friedman, "Learning To Negotiate Reality."

¹⁴ Hamilton and Woodward-Kron, "Developing Cultural Awareness and Intercultural Communication through Multimedia."

¹⁵ Antal and Friedman, "Learning To Negotiate Reality."

¹⁶ Maria Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments': From Cultural Awareness and Cross-cultural Mediation to Critical Intercultural Language Pedagogy," *Pedagogy, Culture & Society* 19, no. 1 (2011): 21–39, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14681366.2011.527118>.

¹⁷ Kim, "Intercultural Personhood."

¹⁸ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

¹⁹ Antal and Friedman, "Learning To Negotiate Reality."

²⁰ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

²¹ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

Communicating in numerous cultures takes more than just knowing another language. Experiencing cultural differences is necessary and using language in ways that fit each specific situation²². Even perfect grammar and vocabulary do not always lead to understanding, since communication is also shaped by beliefs, expectations, and nonverbal signals²³.

For example, a Thai student may silently disagree, while their international counterpart may expect to disagree openly. Both approaches are correct, as they are a product of culture. Misunderstandings exist when people expect disagreement to be handled in ways they are accustomed to, or when they choose language they believe is appropriate²⁴.

Intercultural interactions have various advantages. More specifically, these interactions can lead to new friendships, improved cross-cultural communication skills, and valuable opportunities to learn together²⁵.

Related Forms of Communication

Intracultural, cross-cultural, and intercultural communication are closely related, but each focus on something slightly different. Intracultural communication happens between people who share a broad cultural background²⁶. Still, that does not mean everyone involved has the same experiences; factors like age, maturity, education, and life experience can all shape how people connect and interact²⁷.

Cross-cultural research compares how communication works in two or more cultural settings²⁸. A researcher might examine how students in Thailand and Japan communicate with their teachers and then consider where their communication practices are similar or different.

Intercultural communication is about the real, direct conversations that happen between people from different cultures²⁹. Through talking and listening, people can learn to understand each other, find common ground, and even build new communities that celebrate their differences³⁰. Of course, the lines between these types of communication can be blurry, since most of us belong to several different cultural and social groups at the same time.

²² Huang and Xu, "A Study of Culture Teaching in College English Teaching."

²³ Hamilton and Woodward-Kron, "Developing Cultural Awareness and Intercultural Communication through Multimedia."

²⁴ Hamilton and Woodward-Kron, "Developing Cultural Awareness and Intercultural Communication through Multimedia."

²⁵ Patricia Dooley, "Students' Perspectives of an EAP Pathway Program," *Journal of English for Academic Purposes* 9, no. 3 (2010): 184–97, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jeap.2010.02.013>.

²⁶ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

²⁷ Sonja De Leeuw and Ingegerd Rydin, "Migrant Children's Digital Stories: Identity Formation and Self-Representation through Media Production," *European Journal of Cultural Studies* 10, no. 4 (2007): 447–64, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1367549407081948>.

²⁸ Hopson et al., "Meeting in the Middle."

²⁹ Huang and Xu, "A Study of Culture Teaching in College English Teaching."

³⁰ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

The Importance of Context

Context is everything that surrounds a conversation, not just the words people say. It can include how long people have known each other, who has more power, and what is happening around them³¹. Studies of communication in settings such as schools and workplaces show that relationships, the languages people use, social roles, expectations, and even emotions all play a part in shaping how interactions unfold³².

Take the phrase, “That is interesting.” A teacher might say it as a compliment, a friend could use it to show surprise, or someone else might use those words to avoid disagreeing directly. To figure out what’s really meant, you have to pay attention to the speaker’s tone of voice, facial expression, your relationship with them, and the situation you’re both in.

Context gets even more important when people come from different languages and cultural backgrounds. To communicate well across cultures, you must pay attention to what is normal or expected in that culture: both how people use language and what they consider polite or respectful³³. For instance, a student might remain quiet as a sign of respect, but a teacher might think their silence indicates they are not interested. One person might see directness as honest, while someone else could find it rude.

When people encounter culturally unfamiliar behavior, they should consider possible explanations rather than judge it as abnormal simply because it differs from the norms of their own culture³⁴. You can watch what is going on, look for clues in the situation, and ask questions if you are not sure what something means³⁵. Our own cultural backgrounds affect the expectations and roles we bring to a conversation³⁶. That is why, in intercultural situations, it is important to talk openly about how people’s perspectives and interpretations might be shaped by their cultures³⁷.

CULTURE, IDENTITY, AND COMMUNICATION

Culture does not influence everyone in the same way. Important differences exist both between cultural groups and among people within the same group³⁸. Individuals also participate in several social and cultural groups simultaneously. Their contact with different communities contributes to the development of multiple identities³⁹. Identity concerns how people understand themselves and

³¹ Axelson, “Vocatives.”

³² Claudio Baraldi, “Forms of Mediation: The Case of Interpreter-Mediated Interactions in Medical Systems,” *Language and Intercultural Communication* 9, no. 2 (2009): 120–37, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14708470802588393>.

³³ Hamilton and Woodward-Kron, “Developing Cultural Awareness and Intercultural Communication through Multimedia.”

³⁴ Anne Bartel-Radic and Jean-Luc Giannelloni, “A Renewed Perspective on the Measurement of Cross-Cultural Competence: An Approach through Personality Traits and Cross-Cultural Knowledge,” *European Management Journal* 35, no. 5 (2017): 632–44, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.emj.2017.02.003>.

³⁵ Hamilton and Woodward-Kron, “Developing Cultural Awareness and Intercultural Communication through Multimedia.”

³⁶ Baraldi, “Forms of Mediation.”

³⁷ Antal and Friedman, “Learning To Negotiate Reality.”

³⁸ Prue Holmes, “Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication: Ethnic Chinese Students in a New Zealand University,” *Business Communication Quarterly* 67, no. 3 (2004): 294–307, <https://doi.org/10.1177/1080569904268141>.

³⁹ Dasli, “Reviving the ‘Moments.’”

is constructed through language and social contexts⁴⁰. Communication allows people to express these identities, participate in social life, and establish relationships with others⁴¹.

Understanding Identity

Identity refers to a person's understanding of who they are and how they relate to other people and social groups. It develops through membership in different communities and through continued interaction with others⁴². Identity includes social positions connected to factors such as gender, age, social class, and ethnicity⁴³.

People from the same cultural background do not always think, communicate, or behave alike because each person has different life experiences⁴⁴. At the same time, students' reflections on identity showed that their sense of belonging was connected to family, religion, social class, and other social groups⁴⁵. Identity is therefore shaped by a person's individual experiences and social connections.

People may hold national, ethnic, linguistic, gender, and professional identities⁴⁶. Their membership in particular communities can provide shared norms, values, and unwritten expectations about appropriate behavior⁴⁷. National identity develops through a person's connection with an imagined national community, while ethnicity provides another position through which a person may understand and express who they are⁴⁸. Gender, race, and social class are also dimensions of cultural identity that are constructed through communication and can influence how communication occurs⁴⁹.

Multiple and Intersecting Identities

A person does not have only one identity. Individuals develop multiple identities through their membership in different groups and their contact with different communities⁵⁰. For example, someone may identify as Thai, Buddhist, multilingual, a university student, a daughter, and a future business professional at the same time.

⁴⁰ Dooley, "Students' Perspectives of an EAP Pathway Program."

⁴¹ Loyal Kasselas Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities," *Journal of Youth Studies* 17, no. 3 (2014): 308–23, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13676261.2013.815706>.

⁴² Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

⁴³ Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities."

⁴⁴ Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

⁴⁵ Francesca Helm, "Language and Culture in an Online Context: What Can Learner Diaries Tell Us about Intercultural Competence?," *Language and Intercultural Communication* 9, no. 2 (2009): 91–104, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14708470802140260>.

⁴⁶ Melinda Ann Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s): Implications for Teacher Education in the Twenty-First Century," *Language and Intercultural Communication* 11, no. 4 (2011): 319–37, <https://doi.org/10.1080/14708477.2011.599390>.

⁴⁷ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

⁴⁸ Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities."

⁴⁹ Dreama G. Moon, "Concepts of 'Culture': Implications for Intercultural Communication Research," *Communication Quarterly* 44, no. 1 (1996): 70–84, <https://doi.org/10.1080/01463379609370001>.

⁵⁰ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

These identities do not operate separately. Cultural identity can include connected dimensions such as race, gender, and social class, which should be considered together⁵¹. An international female student's experiences, for example, may be influenced by her nationality, gender, age, language ability, and position as a student outside her home country. The combination of these identities may shape how other people respond to her and how she experiences university life.

People who share one identity may still differ in important ways. Two students from the same country may have different religions, languages, personalities, family backgrounds, or educational experiences. Treating a cultural group as homogeneous hides differences among members of national, ethnic, gender, and racial groups⁵². Nationality or any other single identity cannot fully explain how an individual thinks, communicates, or behaves.

Identity as Dynamic and Context-Dependent

Identity is not static. People's group affiliations and self-understandings remain open to negotiation⁵³. Entering university, moving abroad, learning another language, developing new relationships, or beginning a career may change how people understand themselves.

Identity is also context-dependent because it develops through interaction among particular people in specific historical, geographical, and social circumstances⁵⁴. Different identities may become more noticeable in different situations. At university, a person's identity as a student may be important. At home, that person's family identity may become more relevant. In a workplace, professional identity may influence communication.

A student may use standard Italian at university but speak in a local dialect with friends. This change reflects an awareness of the audience and the relationship between the speakers⁵⁵. Using different forms of language in different situations is not necessarily dishonest. It can be an appropriate response to the people involved.

Culture and Communication

Culture provides some of the beliefs, values, assumptions, and expectations that people use when communicating⁵⁶. In settings where hierarchy is important, communication may involve indirect disagreement, conflict avoidance, nonverbal expressions of politeness, and respect for people with higher social status⁵⁷.

Classroom participation is not always easy to interpret. A quiet student may still be following the lesson closely. The student may have learned not to question a teacher in public or may find it

⁵¹ Moon, "Concepts of 'Culture.'"

⁵² Moon, "Concepts of 'Culture.'"

⁵³ Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities."

⁵⁴ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

⁵⁵ Helm, "Language and Culture in an Online Context."

⁵⁶ Kelsy Lin Ulrey and Patricia Amason, "Intercultural Communication Between Patients and Health Care Providers: An Exploration of Intercultural Communication Effectiveness, Cultural Sensitivity, Stress, and Anxiety," *Health Communication* 13, no. 4 (2001): 449–63, https://doi.org/10.1207/S15327027HC1304_06.

⁵⁷ Mora Claramita et al., "Doctor–Patient Communication in Southeast Asia: A Different Culture?," *Advances in Health Sciences Education* 18, no. 1 (2013): 15–31, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10459-012-9352-5>.

difficult to express ideas in the language used in class. Previous schooling, language difficulties, and familiar communication practices can influence participation in a new academic setting⁵⁸.

Culture is only one possible influence on communication. Personal experience, language ability, personality, relationships, emotions, and the purpose of the interaction may also affect behavior. Intercultural communication should therefore be understood through people's individual experiences because meaningful differences exist both between and within cultural groups⁵⁹. Cultural patterns may help people consider possible explanations for behavior, but they should not be treated as rules that determine how every person will communicate.

Communication and Identity

People express identity through language, names, clothing, jewelry, flags, and other culturally meaningful symbols. These symbols can communicate national, ethnic, and religious affiliations⁶⁰. A multilingual student may use one language with family members, another in class, and a combination of languages with friends. These choices may communicate comfort, respect, closeness, or group membership.

Communication does more than express an identity that already exists. It also contributes to the construction of identity. Through social participation, people develop identities that others can recognize⁶¹. For example, encouragement from classmates may help a student develop an identity as a confident English speaker. Repeated exclusion may cause another student to feel that they do not belong.

Identity is also negotiated during interaction. Group affiliations are not fixed because they remain open to interpretation and negotiation⁶². Other people may describe someone as a foreigner, a local student, a leader, an expert, or a beginner. These descriptions may not match how that person understands themselves.

A person's name is more personal than a label such as "the international student." Using the name that a classmate prefers recognizes how that person wishes to be addressed. This attention to the individual reflects an other-centered approach to intercultural communication⁶³.

Perception, Belonging, and Inclusion

Perception involves constructing and processing the meaning of social experiences, including feelings, communication, behavior, and personality⁶⁴. People may form impressions of others from their appearance, language, accent, or behavior. Clothing, jewelry, flags, and religious symbols may make some aspects of national, ethnic, or religious identity visible⁶⁵. However, visible features reveal only part of a person's identity.

⁵⁸ Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

⁵⁹ Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

⁶⁰ Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities."

⁶¹ Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities."

⁶² Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities."

⁶³ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

⁶⁴ Scholl, "The Socio-Emotional Basis of Human Interaction and Communication."

⁶⁵ Wiltgren, "Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities."

Finding the right words in English can take time. Language difficulties may place students at a disadvantage during classroom interaction⁶⁶. Therefore, patience is a necessity.

Belonging is connected to identifying oneself as a member of a family, religious group, social class, or other social groups⁶⁷. Inclusion allows people to express multiple identities, participate in social activities, and establish relationships with their peers⁶⁸. Inclusive communication, therefore, requires more than simply allowing people to be physically present. It involves creating meaningful opportunities for them to speak, contribute, and be recognized.

“Do you mean that you disagree?” is a more preferable response. This allows the classmate the opportunity to explain and reflect on the other-centered communication associated with intercultural competence⁶⁹.

Avoiding Stereotypes and Overgeneralizations

Stereotypes treat members of a diverse group as if they are all the same. This approach hides important differences within national, ethnic, gender, and racial groups⁷⁰. Statements such as “Asian students are quiet” or “Westerners are direct” reduce complex individuals to simple cultural categories. They also ignore the influence of personality, relationships, language ability, education, and context.

A cultural generalization is different from a stereotype. A generalization identifies a pattern that may appear within a group, but it does not necessarily explain the experiences or behavior of every member⁷¹. Generalizations can provide a starting point for learning, but they must remain open to individual and situational variation. Cultural groups contain internal differences and contradictions that prevent one cultural model from representing all their members⁷².

Knowing that silence can carry different cultural meanings does not explain why a particular classmate is quiet. Asking the person and listening to the answer reflects the other-centered nature of intercultural competence⁷³. This kind of dialogue allows participants to explore cultural differences as they develop shared meaning⁷⁴.

INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION IN CONTEMPORARY LIFE

Intercultural communication has become increasingly important as communities become more culturally diverse⁷⁵. People regularly interact with members of other communities whose beliefs, values, and ways of acting may differ from their own⁷⁶. These interactions take place in universities, workplaces, travel, friendships, families, and digital environments. They can create

⁶⁶ Holmes, “Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication.”

⁶⁷ Helm, “Language and Culture in an Online Context.”

⁶⁸ Wiltgren, “Youth Using National Symbols in Constructing Identities.”

⁶⁹ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, “Intercultural Communication Competence.”

⁷⁰ Moon, “Concepts of ‘Culture.’”

⁷¹ Holmes, “Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication.”

⁷² Dasli, “Reviving the ‘Moments.’”

⁷³ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, “Intercultural Communication Competence.”

⁷⁴ Dasli, “Reviving the ‘Moments.’”

⁷⁵ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, “Intercultural Communication Competence.”

⁷⁶ Dasli, “Reviving the ‘Moments.’”

misunderstandings, but they can also provide opportunities for cooperation, learning, and stronger relationships.

Globalization and Cultural Diversity

Globalization has increased connections among people, institutions, and communities across national borders. Digital communication allows multicultural communities to develop even when their members live in different countries⁷⁷. Technology reduces the limitations created by physical distance and expands opportunities for international communication and intercultural learning⁷⁸.

Communities are becoming increasingly multicultural as people travel, migrate, study, work, and communicate internationally⁷⁹. Universities, for example, may bring host-country students together with international students from different cultural backgrounds⁸⁰. Educational travel can also create direct contact between visitors and members of host communities⁸¹.

Cultural diversity creates both opportunities and challenges. People can encounter new perspectives and learn about unfamiliar practices, but different communication and learning expectations may also cause difficulties⁸². Participants may hold different ideas about what is polite, respectful, or appropriate in a particular situation⁸³. Limited ability in one another's languages can make communication more difficult⁸⁴.

Two students from differing cultures having a conversation may not lead to intercultural learning. Learning begins when the encounter leads a person to question familiar assumptions and take another perspective seriously⁸⁵.

Intercultural Communication in Universities

Universities can create culturally diverse classrooms and campuses where international students and host-country students learn together⁸⁶. Intercultural interaction may occur during classroom discussions, group projects, student activities, and online exchanges. In one international online project, student teachers in Spain and the United States collaborated with partners in another country⁸⁷.

⁷⁷ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

⁷⁸ Helm, "Language and Culture in an Online Context."

⁷⁹ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

⁸⁰ Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

⁸¹ Cinzia Mancini-Cross et al., "The Effect of the Language Barrier on Intercultural Communication: A Case Study of Educational Travel in Italy," *Journal of Teaching in Travel & Tourism* 9, nos. 1–2 (2009): 104–23, <https://doi.org/10.1080/15313220903042004>.

⁸² Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

⁸³ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

⁸⁴ Mancini-Cross et al., "The Effect of the Language Barrier on Intercultural Communication."

⁸⁵ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

⁸⁶ Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

⁸⁷ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

There are numerous reasons why a student may be quiet. Teachers' expectations regarding acceptable classroom behavior affect how students participate⁸⁸. In an intercultural learning project, participation was associated with enthusiasm and engagement⁸⁹.

International students may also face roadblocks while collaborating. Students may have different schedules, program requirements, intended outcomes, and expectations about group responsibilities⁹⁰. If these differences remain unspoken, participants may incorrectly assume that others are careless or uncooperative.

Intercultural competence involves listening and showing respect, and students' communication skills may also develop by asking appropriate questions, learning about their classmates, and adapting their messages when necessary⁹¹. Dialogic classroom practices give learners opportunities to express different perspectives and contribute culturally influenced interpretations to discussions⁹². In this way, diversity becomes a resource for learning rather than simply a possible source of difficulty.

Intercultural Communication in the Workplace

Many organizations employ people from different cultural backgrounds. Managers and employees must therefore recognize that cultural differences may influence workplace communication and interaction⁹³. Business communication may include exchanging messages, responding to inquiries, giving instructions, and sharing information across countries and cultures⁹⁴.

If International co-workers disagree about how to complete a task, they may discuss the problem directly, compromise, accommodate a colleague, or avoid the disagreement⁹⁵. When English is used as a shared language, clear explanations become especially important⁹⁶. This applies during meetings, telephone calls, and other workplace discussions⁹⁷.

⁸⁸ Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

⁸⁹ Helm, "Language and Culture in an Online Context."

⁹⁰ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

⁹¹ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

⁹² Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

⁹³ Maria Mushaathoni, "Workers' Perceptions Regarding Approaches To Intercultural Communication In The Workplace: A Study In A South African University," *Journal of Intercultural Communication*, March 1, 2024, 174–88, <https://doi.org/10.36923/jicc.v24i1.325>.

⁹⁴ Hussain Ahmed Liton, "ESP Learners' Needs Related Learning for the Workplace: A Pragmatic Study for Business School," *International Journal of Instruction* 8, no. 2 (2015): 3–16, <https://doi.org/10.12973/iji.2015.821a>.

⁹⁵ Jihyun Kim and Renée A. Meyers, "Cultural Differences in Conflict Management Styles in East and West Organizations Employing Holism as a Cultural Theoretical Frame to Investigate South Korean and U.S. Employee Conflict Management Styles," *Journal of Intercultural Communication* 12, no. 2 (2012): 1–14, <https://doi.org/10.36923/jicc.v12i2.596>.

⁹⁶ Shulin Yu and Bee Eng Wong, "Preparing Chinese Higher Vocational Students to Succeed in a Globalized and Multicultural World: Enhancing Their Oral English Competence and Intercultural Competence," *Acta Psychologica* 263 (March 2026): 106253, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.actpsy.2026.106253>.

⁹⁷ Liton, "ESP Learners' Needs Related Learning for the Workplace."

Individuals can adjust dialogue to a new language environment⁹⁸. Observing how others communicate is helpful⁹⁹.

Intercultural Communication During Travel

International travel places people in unfamiliar cultural environments where they may experience culture shock and communicate with local residents¹⁰⁰. Travelers may encounter unfamiliar languages, laws, religious practices, greetings, clothing expectations, and standards of public behavior. Everyday activities such as ordering food, using transportation, and asking for directions may therefore involve intercultural communication.

Traveling to a new country can develop intercultural competence when students try to communicate with people about their lives and traditions¹⁰¹. Travelers should observe their surroundings and avoid judging unfamiliar behavior.

Travelers do not need to worry about offending someone, as they can leave, seek help, or refuse a request. Reflection may help travelers understand unfamiliar experiences without excusing harmful conduct¹⁰².

Friendships, Families, and Everyday Life

Intercultural communication also occurs among friends. Through dialogue, friends from different linguistic and cultural backgrounds can express their identities, explore cultural differences, and develop shared meaning¹⁰³. This may strengthen a friendship when participants understand it in similar ways. However, it may cause discomfort or exclusion when its meaning is misunderstood¹⁰⁴.

Intercultural families may use aspects from different cultural backgrounds. Families living outside their country of origin may continue using family languages, maintain cultural traditions, and communicate regularly with relatives in other countries¹⁰⁵. Family members may need to discuss which languages to use, which traditions to maintain, and how to manage different expectations within the household.

Two friends may disagree about whether a comment was rude. Instead of assuming the worst, one friend can ask what the other person meant and listen to the explanation. This conversation gives both people a chance to understand the disagreement and decide how to move forward¹⁰⁶.

⁹⁸ Marie Møller Jensen and Lotte Dam, "Verbal Humor in Intercultural Workplaces and Second Language Learning: An Overview of Main Research Directions in the Last 20 Years," *Suvremena Lingvistika* 49, no. 95 (2023): 131–49, <https://doi.org/10.22210/suvlin.2023.095.06>.

⁹⁹ Mushaathoni, "Workers' Perceptions Regarding Approaches To Intercultural Communication In The Workplace."

¹⁰⁰ Mancini-Cross et al., "The Effect of the Language Barrier on Intercultural Communication."

¹⁰¹ Mancini-Cross et al., "The Effect of the Language Barrier on Intercultural Communication."

¹⁰² Helm, "Language and Culture in an Online Context."

¹⁰³ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

¹⁰⁴ Møller Jensen and Dam, "Verbal Humor in Intercultural Workplaces and Second Language Learning."

¹⁰⁵ De Leeuw and Rydin, "Migrant Children's Digital Stories."

¹⁰⁶ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

Arasaratnam and Doerfel¹⁰⁷ describe this attention to the other person as an important part of intercultural competence.

Benefits of Effective Intercultural Communication

Effective intercultural communication can provide academic, professional, and personal benefits. Academically, online intercultural exchanges can help students collaborate with international partners, exchange knowledge and opinions, and develop communication skills for multilingual and multicultural education¹⁰⁸. Intercultural preparation can also help international students understand unfamiliar educational practices and adjust to a new university environment¹⁰⁹.

Intercultural encounters can expose students to different perspectives and encourage them to examine both other cultures and their own cultural assumptions¹¹⁰. These experiences may encourage curiosity, openness, critical reflection, and greater awareness of stereotypes¹¹¹. Intercultural learning can also help people question cultural representations, reconsider their assumptions, and evaluate their own interpretations more carefully¹¹².

If coworkers misunderstand each other, work can be delayed¹¹³. A quick conversation about the task or deadline can resolve the issue and let everyone get back on track. Employees who use English effectively and are aware of cultural differences tend to adjust more quickly to new work environments¹¹⁴.

Environments will almost certainly have misunderstandings. Therefore, when confusion arises, people can discuss what was said and clarify what each person meant¹¹⁵. Intercultural competence also needs the other person and a willingness to adjust one's communication as the relationship develops¹¹⁶.

INTERCULTURAL COMMUNICATION IN THAILAND AND ASEAN

Thailand offers something for neighboring countries. Thai universities bring together local students, international students, and faculty members from ASEAN and other parts of the Asia-Pacific region¹¹⁷. These intercultural encounters allow students to learn about different cultural perspectives and develop relationships across cultural boundaries.

¹⁰⁷ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

¹⁰⁸ Dooley, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

¹⁰⁹ Holmes, "Negotiating Differences in Learning and Intercultural Communication."

¹¹⁰ Prue Holmes and Gillian O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence: Ethnographies of Intercultural Encounters," *International Journal of Intercultural Relations* 36, no. 5 (2012): 707–18, <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijintrel.2012.04.010>.

¹¹¹ Helm, "Language and Culture in an Online Context."

¹¹² Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

¹¹³ Mushaathoni, "Workers' Perceptions Regarding Approaches To Intercultural Communication In The Workplace."

¹¹⁴ Yu and Wong, "Preparing Chinese Higher Vocational Students to Succeed in a Globalized and Multicultural World."

¹¹⁵ Møller Jensen and Dam, "Verbal Humor in Intercultural Workplaces and Second Language Learning."

¹¹⁶ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

¹¹⁷ Viseshiri Pongsin et al., "Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub: Major Challenges and Opportunities, a Policy Analysis," *Research in Comparative and International Education* 18, no. 2 (2023): 249–76, <https://doi.org/10.1177/17454999231163401>.

ASEAN consists of societies with diverse cultural backgrounds and national interests. This diversity can make the development of a shared regional identity more complex¹¹⁸. Structured intercultural learning can help students become more aware of cultural diversity, strengthen their interpersonal skills, and communicate more confidently with people from different backgrounds¹¹⁹. Understanding the region therefore requires attention to diversity within Thailand, differences across ASEAN, and the communication practices that emerge when people meet.

Diversity within Thailand

Thailand is sometimes described as having one language and one culture. However, the country contains considerable cultural and linguistic diversity. An international student studying in Thailand reported discovering that the country was more culturally and linguistically diverse than previously understood¹²⁰.

Thai people have different views. Although they live in Thailand, they interpret situations in distinct ways. Nationality itself does not account for these differences¹²¹.

Communication may be influenced by age, socioeconomic position, education, exposure to other cultures, occupation, and organizational membership¹²². Regional background, family experience, language use, and generation may also influence how people understand social situations. People living within the same country should therefore not be treated as a homogeneous cultural group because this approach hides important differences among them¹²³.

Thai and International Students

Universities in Thailand bring Thai students into contact with international students from ASEAN, the wider Asia-Pacific region, and other parts of the world¹²⁴. These students may interact through culturally mixed classes, small-group activities, and multicultural projects¹²⁵.

These situations help students bond and learn different viewpoints¹²⁶. However, this does not guarantee that intercultural communication takes place. It is possible that students may remain with familiar friends because doing so feels more comfortable.

¹¹⁸ Pinn Siraprasiri and Chanintira Na Thalang, "Towards the ASEAN Community: Assessing the Knowledge, Attitudes, and Aspirations of Thai University Students," *Journal of Current Southeast Asian Affairs* 35, no. 2 (2016): 113–47, <https://doi.org/10.1177/186810341603500205>.

¹¹⁹ Anita S. Mak et al., "Fostering Cultural Inclusiveness and Learning in Culturally Mixed Business Classes," *SpringerPlus* 3, no. 1 (2014): 242, <https://doi.org/10.1186/2193-1801-3-242>.

¹²⁰ Pongsin et al., "Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub."

¹²¹ Moon, "Concepts of 'Culture.'"

¹²² Mushaathoni, "Workers' Perceptions Regarding Approaches To Intercultural Communication In The Workplace."

¹²³ Moon, "Concepts of 'Culture.'"

¹²⁴ Pongsin et al., "Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub."

¹²⁵ Mak et al., "Fostering Cultural Inclusiveness and Learning in Culturally Mixed Business Classes."

¹²⁶ Pongsin et al., "Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub."

Some Thai university students hesitate to speak English for fear of being judged by others¹²⁷. On the other hand, international students may be unfamiliar with classroom participation practices in Thailand because educational cultures hold different expectations about appropriate communication¹²⁸.

Positive interaction requires cooperation from everyone involved¹²⁹. Students can contribute to inclusive classrooms by encouraging participation and creating opportunities for classmates to share their experiences¹³⁰. It is important to note that limited proficiency in the language of a group does not indicate limited knowledge or expertise¹³¹.

Communication in Thai Contexts

Communication in Thai university classrooms may be influenced by relationships between teachers and students and by expectations concerning hierarchy, politeness, and social harmony¹³². How someone is addressed can communicate formality, social status, intimacy, and the relationship between speakers, and choosing between a personal name and a formal title can therefore function as a politeness strategy and indicate social closeness or belonging¹³³.

Some students may avoid speaking if they believe that doing so could lead to negative judgment or a loss of face¹³⁴. Students may also remain silent rather than directly question or criticize a teacher because they do not want to appear impolite¹³⁵. In classrooms where status differences are strongly recognized, attentive listening and limited public questioning may be understood as appropriate ways of communicating with lecturers¹³⁶.

These patterns describe possible influences. Thai students differ considerably in their willingness to speak. Quietness may result from shyness, anxiety, limited confidence, fear of judgment, or difficulty expressing ideas in English¹³⁷. Communication in multicultural groups may also be influenced by language barriers, cultural differences, individual personalities, and relationships among group members¹³⁸.

¹²⁷ Thinley Wangdi and Ringphami Shimray, "Exploring the Reticence of Thai University Students in English Classrooms: Student-Centred Coping Strategies," *Journal of Education Culture and Society* 16, no. 2 (2025): 297–315, <https://doi.org/10.15503/jecs2025.3.297.315>.

¹²⁸ Li Bai and Ying Xian Wang, "In-Class and out-of-Class Interactions between International Students and Their Host University Teachers," *Research in Comparative and International Education* 17, no. 1 (2022): 71–88, <https://doi.org/10.1177/17454999211038774>.

¹²⁹ Mushaathoni, "Workers' Perceptions Regarding Approaches To Intercultural Communication In The Workplace."

¹³⁰ Mak et al., "Fostering Cultural Inclusiveness and Learning in Culturally Mixed Business Classes."

¹³¹ Axelson, "Vocatives."

¹³² Adriano Quieti and Alexander Nanni, "Characteristics of Effective English Language Teachers: Student and Teacher Perspectives at a Thai University," *Sage Open* 12, no. 2 (2022): 21582440221103523, <https://doi.org/10.1177/21582440221103523>.

¹³³ Axelson, "Vocatives."

¹³⁴ Wangdi and Shimray, "Exploring the Reticence of Thai University Students in English Classrooms."

¹³⁵ Quieti and Nanni, "Characteristics of Effective English Language Teachers."

¹³⁶ Bai and Wang, "In-Class and out-of-Class Interactions between International Students and Their Host University Teachers."

¹³⁷ Wangdi and Shimray, "Exploring the Reticence of Thai University Students in English Classrooms."

¹³⁸ Mak et al., "Fostering Cultural Inclusiveness and Learning in Culturally Mixed Business Classes."

Effective communicators should observe specific situations. They should consider observable information and recognize that individuals are culturally complex¹³⁹. Thai communication patterns may provide a useful starting point, but they should never replace careful observation and direct communication with the individual.

Diversity across ASEAN

ASEAN brings together people from different cultural and social backgrounds¹⁴⁰. International students from across Asia contribute to culturally diverse and multilingual university communities in Thailand¹⁴¹. Religious and ritual practices can also provide resources through which people understand and negotiate their ethnic identities¹⁴².

ASEAN member countries differ politically, economically, and socioculturally. Understanding these differences is important for effective regional cooperation¹⁴³. Diversity also exists within each member country. National populations contain differences connected to gender, social class, social status, ethnicity, and religion¹⁴⁴.

ASEAN should therefore be understood as a community of diverse countries and peoples rather than as one uniform culture¹⁴⁵. Statements such as “ASEAN culture” or “Southeast Asian communication” may hide important differences within and between countries. Regional patterns can support initial understanding, but they should not be used to predict the behavior of every person.

International universities offer both positive and negative aspects¹⁴⁶. Students can learn to examine cross-cultural conflicts and consider the best possible solution for unfamiliar situations¹⁴⁷.

Mobility, Tourism, and Employment

Movement within and beyond ASEAN increases intercultural contact. International university programs in Thailand bring together students from ASEAN and other parts of the Asia-Pacific region¹⁴⁸. Educational travel also gives students opportunities to interact with people in host communities and develop relationships with them¹⁴⁹.

ASEAN cooperation connects member states and their people through economic, political-security, and sociocultural integration¹⁵⁰. These connections can involve governments, universities, businesses, and professional organizations. They create opportunities for cooperation while also requiring people to manage differences in language, expectations, and communication practices.

¹³⁹ Antal and Friedman, “Learning To Negotiate Reality.”

¹⁴⁰ Siraprapasiri and Na Thalang, “Towards the ASEAN Community.”

¹⁴¹ Pongsin et al., “Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub.”

¹⁴² De Leeuw and Rydin, “Migrant Children’s Digital Stories.”

¹⁴³ Siraprapasiri and Na Thalang, “Towards the ASEAN Community.”

¹⁴⁴ Moon, “Concepts of ‘Culture.’”

¹⁴⁵ Siraprapasiri and Na Thalang, “Towards the ASEAN Community.”

¹⁴⁶ Pongsin et al., “Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub.”

¹⁴⁷ Antal and Friedman, “Learning To Negotiate Reality.”

¹⁴⁸ Pongsin et al., “Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub.”

¹⁴⁹ Mancini-Cross et al., “The Effect of the Language Barrier on Intercultural Communication.”

¹⁵⁰ Siraprapasiri and Na Thalang, “Towards the ASEAN Community.”

Colleagues have disagreements. When they recognize their differences, it can help the group continue working together¹⁵¹. Employees can explain their own reasoning and ask what the other person intended¹⁵². Students need practice in these situations¹⁵³.

English and Multilingual Communication

English often functions as the lingua franca among students from different national and cultural backgrounds at international universities in Thailand¹⁵⁴. However, speakers may use different accents, vocabulary, and levels of fluency. International students may find these variations difficult to understand¹⁵⁵.

Lecturers may also be difficult to understand when they speak quickly or use unfamiliar accents and expressions¹⁵⁶. Communication can be supported through repetition, examples, gestures, translation, and the use of more than one language. The main goal is not to copy one native-speaker model. It is to create mutual understanding.

A multilingual university environment may provide avenues for language development and intercultural learning¹⁵⁷. Students can learn World Englishes and from the other languages present in their community. Multilingual communication should therefore be treated as a resource rather than simply as a problem.

Knowledge of Thai and ASEAN communication patterns can be useful, but it must be applied carefully. Individuals should not be reduced to national or cultural categories because these labels may hide important differences within groups¹⁵⁸. Successful intercultural communication requires openness, sensitivity, careful listening, interest in others, and a willingness to learn¹⁵⁹. These qualities allow students to draw on cultural knowledge without reducing it to a fixed assumption about another person.

FACE-TO-FACE AND DIGITAL INTERCULTURAL ENCOUNTERS

Intercultural communication happens in both face-to-face and digital settings¹⁶⁰. In all cases, participants create shared meaning influenced by their own perspectives, as well as by social, cultural, and situational factors¹⁶¹. Face-to-face and digital communication each provide unique

¹⁵¹ Mushaathoni, "Workers' Perceptions Regarding Approaches To Intercultural Communication In The Workplace."

¹⁵² Antal and Friedman, "Learning To Negotiate Reality."

¹⁵³ Yu and Wong, "Preparing Chinese Higher Vocational Students to Succeed in a Globalized and Multicultural World."

¹⁵⁴ Pongsin et al., "Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub."

¹⁵⁵ Bai and Wang, "In-Class and out-of-Class Interactions between International Students and Their Host University Teachers."

¹⁵⁶ Bai and Wang, "In-Class and out-of-Class Interactions between International Students and Their Host University Teachers."

¹⁵⁷ Pongsin et al., "Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub."

¹⁵⁸ Moon, "Concepts of 'Culture.'"

¹⁵⁹ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

¹⁶⁰ Bai and Wang, "In-Class and out-of-Class Interactions between International Students and Their Host University Teachers."

¹⁶¹ Dooley, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

cues and opportunities. Understanding these differences helps individuals choose suitable communication methods and avoid misunderstandings.

Face-to-Face Intercultural Interaction

Face-to-face intercultural communication occurs when participants speak and respond to one another in the same physical setting¹⁶². They can use spoken language while also observing tone, volume, intonation, gestures, body language, and physical space¹⁶³. Facial expressions and vocal signals can help participants interpret emotional and implied meanings¹⁶⁴.

Verbal and nonverbal information function together in communication. Facial expressions and vocal tone can support or change the meaning of spoken words¹⁶⁵. For example, a friendly look may make a direct question seem less harsh, while an impatient tone can make polite words sound unfriendly.

Face-to-face communication allows for immediate feedback, allowing speakers to adjust their messages in real time. A listener's facial expression, posture, or response shows whether a message has been understood. When signs of misunderstanding arise, participants can explain, repeat, rephrase, or ask questions to restore shared understanding¹⁶⁶.

Nonverbal signals do not have universal meanings. A gesture may carry different meanings in different cultural settings and misunderstanding it can produce unexpected reactions¹⁶⁷. Eye contact may communicate respect in one setting, while sustained eye contact with an older person may be considered disrespectful in some Asian and African contexts¹⁶⁸.

Silence can have multiple meanings. In language classrooms, it may signal respect for teachers or classmates, but it can also result from difficulty understanding instructions, limited language proficiency, or anxiety¹⁶⁹. Similarly, facial expressions should not be interpreted in isolation, as their meaning depends on context and the direction of a person's gaze¹⁷⁰. Effective communicators consider the entire situation rather than drawing conclusions from a single signal.

Digital Intercultural Communication

Digital technologies enable people in different locations to connect through forums, email, instant messaging, social media, video conferencing, learning platforms, and virtual environments¹⁷¹. Consequently, these tools support communication across national borders and time zones.

¹⁶² Axelson, "Vocatives."

¹⁶³ Mancini-Cross et al., "The Effect of the Language Barrier on Intercultural Communication."

¹⁶⁴ Scholl, "The Socio-Emotional Basis of Human Interaction and Communication."

¹⁶⁵ Scholl, "The Socio-Emotional Basis of Human Interaction and Communication."

¹⁶⁶ Romero-Trillo and Lenn, "Do You '(Mis)Understand' What I Mean?"

¹⁶⁷ Huang and Xu, "A Study of Culture Teaching in College English Teaching."

¹⁶⁸ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

¹⁶⁹ Wangdi and Shimray, "Exploring the Reticence of Thai University Students in English Classrooms."

¹⁷⁰ Scholl, "The Socio-Emotional Basis of Human Interaction and Communication."

¹⁷¹ Dooley, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

A quick LINE message may suit a conversation between friends but seem too casual when sent to a lecturer. People communicate both face-to-face and online¹⁷², and the meaning of a message depends on the situation in which people exchange it¹⁷³. Considering the situation before speaking or writing can prevent misunderstandings.

People in different countries can work together on the same project using digital platforms¹⁷⁴. When they collaborate online, language learners have the chance to practice the language and learn about other cultures¹⁷⁵. These methods also make it easier for students to interact with one another and learn as a group¹⁷⁶.

Digital intercultural communication differs from face-to-face interaction. It allows people who have limited international contact to form connections, share ideas, and join intercultural learning experiences.

Challenges in Digital Environments

Digital communication usually provides less context and fewer nonverbal cues than face-to-face exchanges. Written email does not show typical nonverbal signals, so people may use emoticons or symbols to show feelings and intentions¹⁷⁷. These symbols may be interpreted differently by various groups or age ranges.

People from different cultures may have different ideas about how to communicate online. The way people interact can also change depending on the digital platform they use. For example, live chat conversations can be interrupted more easily, while emails or instant messages are usually more direct¹⁷⁸. Sometimes, students do not agree about how formal a message should be, how quickly someone should reply, or if it is okay to use informal language. For instance, one student might start an email to a teacher with a formal greeting, but another student might write more casually, as if speaking to a friend.

Humor can be difficult to understand in intercultural communication because people from different cultures joke differently and use language differently, and sometimes, a joke made by one person might seem rude or hurtful to someone else¹⁷⁹. It is also hard to understand sarcasm and irony in written messages because readers cannot hear the speaker's voice or tone (Scholl, 2013).

When people communicate online, they sometimes share more personal information and feel closer to others¹⁸⁰. However, anything shared digitally can be easily copied and sent to people

¹⁷² Bai and Wang, "In-Class and out-of-Class Interactions between International Students and Their Host University Teachers."

¹⁷³ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

¹⁷⁴ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

¹⁷⁵ Helm, "Language and Culture in an Online Context."

¹⁷⁶ Vinsensia Anisa Citta Erydani et al., "Exploring Tiktok's Impact on ESP Students' Speaking Engagement," *Jurnal Ilmiah Peuradeun* 13, no. 2 (2025): 847–76, <https://doi.org/10.26811/peuradeun.v13i2.1700>.

¹⁷⁷ Scholl, "The Socio-Emotional Basis of Human Interaction and Communication."

¹⁷⁸ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

¹⁷⁹ Møller Jensen and Dam, "Verbal Humor in Intercultural Workplaces and Second Language Learning."

¹⁸⁰ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

outside the original group¹⁸¹. What someone does online can change how others see them and can also affect relationships in online communities¹⁸². Before posting or forwarding something, it is important to consider how others might interpret it and who might see it.

Responsible and Ethical Digital Communication

Responsible digital communication protects people's dignity, privacy, and ability to participate. Hate speech, threats, harassment, and the publication of private information can harm users' well-being and limit their opportunities to participate in digital social life¹⁸³. Communicators should therefore avoid discriminatory language, personal attacks, harmful stereotypes, and the public sharing of private information.

It is important not to share photos, recordings, screenshots, or private messages without permission. Students should also follow their school's rules, keep their passwords secure, and not claim someone else's ideas as their own. Digital messages can stay online for a long time, so one careless action can affect relationships and reputations far into the future.

People (sometimes) make mistakes when they talk online, especially if nobody helps them¹⁸⁴. In online classes, it is helpful to use simple language, explain things clearly, and give everyone time to speak.

If a student is quiet, it does not mean they do not care. Some students do not talk much because English is hard for them, or they do not understand, or they feel shy or nervous¹⁸⁵. Some students like to help by writing or sharing work. Good online classes let students join in different ways.

People can talk better if they ask questions when they do not understand, say things in a different way, and speak clearly but politely¹⁸⁶. Doing these things helps everyone show respect and share their ideas.

Clarifying and Repairing Misunderstandings

Misunderstandings can occur in both face-to-face and digital communication. When a message seems rude, confusing, or inappropriate, the receiver should avoid reacting immediately. A question such as "Did you mean that...?" or "Could you explain what you meant?" gives the sender an opportunity to clarify.

The person who sends a message should try to fix misunderstandings. This can mean explaining what they meant, noticing how their words made someone feel, and saying sorry if needed. If

¹⁸¹ Viktoria Flasche, "Powerful Entanglements: Interrelationships Between Platform Architectures and Young People's Performance of Self in Social Media," in *Educational Perspectives on Mediality and Subjectivation*, ed. Patrick Bettinger, Palgrave Studies in Educational Media (Springer International Publishing, 2022), https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-84343-4_5.

¹⁸² Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

¹⁸³ Flasche, "Powerful Entanglements."

¹⁸⁴ Erydani et al., "Exploring Tiktok's Impact on ESP Students' Speaking Engagement."

¹⁸⁵ Wangdi and Shimray, "Exploring the Reticence of Thai University Students in English Classrooms."

¹⁸⁶ Fiona Copland and Sue Garton, "'I Felt That I Do Live in the UK Now': International Students' Self-Reports of Their English Language Speaking Experiences on a Pre-Sessional Programme," *Language and Education* 25, no. 3 (2011): 241–55, <https://doi.org/10.1080/09500782.2011.566617>.

someone is hurt, just saying, “That was not my intention,” is often not enough. It is better to show that you understand both what you wanted to say and how it affected the other person.

If a written message is not clear, it can help to try a different way to communicate. For example, people can talk on the phone, send a voice message, have a video call, or meet in person. These ways let people hear each other’s voices, ask questions right away, and explain what they mean.

Sometimes, people do not understand each other right away. It can take time to solve these problems. People should listen carefully and try to see what others mean. When a group works through problems together, they can become better friends¹⁸⁷. Good communication does not mean everything is perfect. It means people notice when something is wrong, explain their ideas again, and are kind if someone makes a mistake.

DEVELOPING INTERCULTURAL COMPETENCE THROUGH PEER-ASSISTING LEARNING

Intercultural competence is the ability to communicate effectively and appropriately with people from different cultural backgrounds by applying relevant knowledge, skills, and attitudes¹⁸⁸. Effective communication helps participants achieve their interactional goals, while appropriate communication responds to the relationship and context¹⁸⁹.

No one can know everything about every culture, and mistakes are a normal part of learning to communicate across cultures. Intercultural competence grows as people meet others, experience different situations, and think about what they have learned¹⁹⁰. Students can become more competent by learning about cultures, being open-minded, practicing communication, paying attention to differences, and acting with respect.

Components of Intercultural Competence

Intercultural competence involves attitudes toward cultural difference, knowledge of social groups, skills for interpreting and engaging with others, and critical cultural awareness¹⁹¹. These components work together during intercultural encounters.

People from different backgrounds may have different values, beliefs, ways of speaking, family systems, or ways of showing feelings¹⁹². By getting to know cultures other than their own, people can see themselves in a new way. They may start to notice that what feels normal or “right” to them is not the same for everyone¹⁹³.

¹⁸⁷ Møller Jensen and Dam, “Verbal Humor in Intercultural Workplaces and Second Language Learning.”

¹⁸⁸ Simone Hackett et al., “The Effectiveness of Collaborative Online International Learning (COIL) on Intercultural Competence Development in Higher Education,” *International Journal of Educational Technology in Higher Education* 20, no. 1 (2023): 5, <https://doi.org/10.1186/s41239-022-00373-3>.

¹⁸⁹ Holmes and O’Neill, “Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence.”

¹⁹⁰ Paweł Sobkowiak, “The Impact of Studying Abroad on Students’ Intercultural Competence: An Interview Study,” *Studies in Second Language Learning and Teaching* 9, no. 4 (2019): 681–710, <https://doi.org/10.14746/ssllt.2019.9.4.6>.

¹⁹¹ Dasli, “Reviving the ‘Moments.’”

¹⁹² Hackett et al., “The Effectiveness of Collaborative Online International Learning (COIL) on Intercultural Competence Development in Higher Education.”

¹⁹³ Holmes and O’Neill, “Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence.”

Cultural knowledge should not become a list of fixed facts about national groups. Its purpose is to help communicators identify possible influences on interaction and ask more informed questions. People should remain open to individual differences and avoid assuming that cultural patterns explain every person's behavior.

People do not all act or think the same way. If someone meets people from another culture, it helps to hold back judgment and give them a chance¹⁹⁴. Wanting to know more about other ways of life can lead to good conversations¹⁹⁵. Being open-minded means trying to understand why people do things differently, instead of jumping to conclusions¹⁹⁶.

Empathy helps people engage with another person's thoughts and understand that person's communication, while respect can support mutual understanding and positive contact¹⁹⁷. Adaptability is also important because communicators may need to change their behavior when their original approach is ineffective. Cross-cultural competence involves recognizing the features of an intercultural situation and adjusting behavior accordingly¹⁹⁸.

When people from different cultures talk, it helps to really listen and watch what others do¹⁹⁹. If something does not make sense, asking about it can help. Often, people do not say everything they mean, so it is important to notice hints and body language as well²⁰⁰.

Observation can help communicators notice facial expressions and vocal signals that provide information about another person's feelings and possible intentions²⁰¹. However, a single expression should not be interpreted without considering the relationship and situation. Intercultural behavior should be examined through several possible explanations rather than through immediate ethnocentric or stereotypical judgments²⁰².

If something is not clear, people can ask the other person to repeat what they said or to explain it in a different way²⁰³. This helps both sides ensure they really understand each other, rather than guessing or assuming.

Being aware of culture means looking closely at your own habits and those of others and thinking about why people do things in different ways²⁰⁴. It is important not to believe that every person in

¹⁹⁴ Sobkowiak, "The Impact of Studying Abroad on Students' Intercultural Competence."

¹⁹⁵ Helen Spencer-Oatey and Daniel Dauber, "Internationalisation and Student Diversity: How Far Are the Opportunity Benefits Being Perceived and Exploited?," *Higher Education* 78, no. 6 (2019): 1035–58, <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10734-019-00386-4>.

¹⁹⁶ Hackett et al., "The Effectiveness of Collaborative Online International Learning (COIL) on Intercultural Competence Development in Higher Education."

¹⁹⁷ Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

¹⁹⁸ Bartel-Radic and Giannelloni, "A Renewed Perspective on the Measurement of Cross-Cultural Competence."

¹⁹⁹ Sobkowiak, "The Impact of Studying Abroad on Students' Intercultural Competence."

²⁰⁰ Møller Jensen and Dam, "Verbal Humor in Intercultural Workplaces and Second Language Learning."

²⁰¹ Scholl, "The Socio-Emotional Basis of Human Interaction and Communication."

²⁰² Bartel-Radic and Giannelloni, "A Renewed Perspective on the Measurement of Cross-Cultural Competence."

²⁰³ Copland and Garton, "'I Felt That I Do Live in the UK Now.'"

²⁰⁴ Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

a country acts the same way. Cultures are not simple, and saying everyone in a group is the same can lead to stereotypes²⁰⁵.

Reflection can help people become more aware of their own assumptions and reconsider judgments, stereotypes, and previous ideas about other cultural groups²⁰⁶. Cultural expectations should not be applied automatically to individuals because treating groups as homogeneous hides important differences within national, ethnic, gender, and racial categories²⁰⁷.

Ethical and Respectful Communication

Intercultural competence includes an ethical responsibility to treat people fairly. It involves promoting tolerance and understanding so that people from all cultural backgrounds are acknowledged, and their human rights are respected²⁰⁸. Respectful intercultural communication recognizes the dignity and rights of people whose backgrounds differ from one's own²⁰⁹.

Equitable communication treats participants as equals and involves them in the shared process of establishing common ground²¹⁰. Equality in culturally diverse classrooms requires equal status and cooperation while still recognizing cultural differences and existing inequalities²¹¹. Equality does not always require treating everyone identically. A second-language speaker, for example, may need more time to respond or may need an unfamiliar expression explained. Providing this support can create a more meaningful opportunity to participate.

Respect also requires appropriate boundaries. Intercultural development includes recognizing the limits of one's knowledge and the boundaries connected to personal identity²¹². Personal stories and family photographs may contain private information that people do not wish to share publicly²¹³. Interest in another culture does not provide the right to ask highly personal questions, touch someone, take photographs, or share another person's experiences without permission.

Respectful communicators observe how others respond and remain sensitive to their needs, wishes, and preferred ways of communicating²¹⁴. They seek consent when necessary and accept that another person may not wish to discuss a particular subject.

²⁰⁵ Michael Handford et al., "Which 'Culture'? A Critical Analysis of Intercultural Communication in Engineering Education," *Journal of Engineering Education* 108, no. 2 (2019): 161–77, <https://doi.org/10.1002/jee.20254>.

²⁰⁶ Sobkowiak, "The Impact of Studying Abroad on Students' Intercultural Competence."

²⁰⁷ Moon, "Concepts of 'Culture.'"

²⁰⁸ Miriam Schwarzenenthal et al., "Reaping the Benefits of Cultural Diversity: Classroom Cultural Diversity Climate and Students' Intercultural Competence," *European Journal of Social Psychology* 50, no. 2 (2020): 323–46, <https://doi.org/10.1002/ejsp.2617>.

²⁰⁹ Mushaathoni, "Workers' Perceptions Regarding Approaches To Intercultural Communication In The Workplace."

²¹⁰ Hopson et al., "Meeting in the Middle."

²¹¹ Schwarzenenthal et al., "Reaping the Benefits of Cultural Diversity."

²¹² Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

²¹³ De Leeuw and Rydin, "Migrant Children's Digital Stories."

²¹⁴ Hopson et al., "Meeting in the Middle."

Peer-Assisted Learning as Intercultural Practice

In Peer-Assisted Learning (henceforth PAL), students learn by working with classmates and talking things through together²¹⁵. No one is the only teacher. Everyone can ask questions, give advice, and try to solve problems as a group.

A PAL center can help students from different countries and languages get to know each other. For example, Thai design students worked and talked with Burmese students from another college during PAL sessions²¹⁶. When students keep meeting, sharing ideas, and working on projects together, they can learn how to understand people from other cultures²¹⁷.

PAL participants may have different responsibilities, but everyone brings knowledge and experience to the interaction. A peer-led approach supports learning through horizontal dialogue and collaborative reflection rather than positioning students only as recipients of information²¹⁸. At Rangsit University, Burmese Team Leaders contribute leadership and cultural experience by encouraging exchange, mediating differences, and helping Thai and international students express themselves during PAL activities²¹⁹. Thai students can contribute knowledge about their customs, values, study habits, etiquette, and communication styles²²⁰.

PAL gives students a chance to use what they learn in class while talking with others. In PAL sessions, students can talk about school topics and look at feedback from AI together²²¹. When people speak different languages, they might hear new accents or ways of speaking. Peer mentors can help by explaining things, saying something again, or using simpler words if needed²²².

Language differences can make it harder for students to talk with each other in PAL sessions, and some students might feel nervous about joining in²²³. If the Team Leader speaks too fast or uses

²¹⁵ Gary Ambito Torremucha and Edward Devere Bacon, "Self-Reported Intercultural Change Through Peer-Assisted Learning within Internationalization at Home: Evidence from Communication Programs," *Proceedings of the 5th Thammasat University International ELT Conference 2026*, 2026, 163–85.

²¹⁶ Edward Devere Bacon and Gary Ambito Torremucha, "Designing Cultural Bridges: A Participatory Action Research Study on Peer-Assisted Learning and Intercultural Competence in Design Education," *CoDesign*, October 6, 2025, 1–25, <https://doi.org/10.1080/15710882.2025.2571801>.

²¹⁷ Edward Devere Bacon and Gessanee Maneerutt, "Navigating Cultural Transitions: The Impact of Peer-Assisted Learning on Burmese Communication Arts and Hospitality Students in Thailand," *Mentoring & Tutoring: Partnership in Learning*, April 23, 2026, 1–21, <https://doi.org/10.1080/13611267.2026.2664600>.

²¹⁸ Bacon and Torremucha, "Designing Cultural Bridges."

²¹⁹ Edward Devere Bacon and Gary Torremucha, "Fostering Leadership and Cultural Integration: Burmese Team Leaders' Role in Peer-Assisted Learning Among Science and Technology Students," July 14, 2025, 299–313, <https://doi.org/10.22492/issn.2186-229X.2025.24>.

²²⁰ Edward Devere Bacon and Gary Ambito Torremucha, "Intercultural Readiness in Motion: Investigating Burmese Business Students' Development within Peer Learning Environments," *Proceedings of the 5th Thammasat University International ELT Conference 2026*, 2026, 145–62.

²²¹ Edward Devere Bacon and Gessanee Maneerutt, "Enhancing EFL Academic Writing through AI and Peer-Assisted Learning," *Journal of Institutional Research South East Asia* 22, no. 3 (2024): 282–314.

²²² Edward Devere Bacon and Catherine De Guzman-Laddawan, "Engaging with Global Englishes through Peer-Assisted Learning: A Controlled Mixed-Methods Study of Burmese International Students as Peer Mentors at a Thai University," *Proceedings of RSU International Research Conference (RSUCON-2026)*, 2026, 77–89, <https://rsucon.rsu.ac.th/proceedings>.

²²³ Bacon and Torremucha, "Fostering Leadership and Cultural Integration."

unfamiliar words, it can be tough for others to follow. Speaking more slowly, giving examples, saying things differently, and asking if everyone understands can help everyone take part.

Mentees take part as well. They can ask questions, speak up if something is confusing, share their own ideas, and help keep the conversation going. Everyone learns more when people talk openly, listen to each other, and do not act like one group knows more or is better than the other²²⁴.

Reflection and Continued Development

Intercultural experience alone does not automatically produce intercultural competence. Contact without reflection may even strengthen cultural stereotypes²²⁵. Students need opportunities to examine what occurred, consider how they interpreted the interaction, and identify what they can learn from it.

Talking together about what happened in a group activity can help students see their own ideas about culture and learn from any problems that came up²²⁶. After a PAL session, students can reflect on their feelings, what they expected would happen, what worked well when talking with others, and how the other people in the group might have seen things.

Students can also identify a specific change for a future PAL session. Participants may reflect on their experience and recommend changes that could improve the learning center²²⁷. One student might decide to speak more slowly, while another might plan to ask more clarification questions or invite quieter group members to contribute.

Intercultural competence grows slowly as people keep meeting, thinking about their experiences, and learning to deal with things they do not understand right away²²⁸. In PAL groups where people use different languages, the main goal is to understand each other, not to speak perfectly²²⁹. People can make mistakes, clear up confusion, change how they speak, and use what they learn next time. PAL provides an authentic setting for peer dialogue and cultural reflection, particularly when its intercultural activities are connected to students' academic courses²³⁰. Through repeated interaction and reflection, students can develop greater openness, communicate more ethically, learn from difficulties, and build relationships based on mutual respect.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

This chapter introduced communication as a shared process through which people create and interpret meaning. The meaning understood by a receiver may differ from the meaning intended by a sender, particularly when participants have different cultural expectations²³¹. Context

²²⁴ Bacon and Torremucha, "Designing Cultural Bridges."

²²⁵ Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

²²⁶ Bacon and Torremucha, "Designing Cultural Bridges."

²²⁷ Edward Devere Bacon et al., "Integrating Seamless Learning within a Peer-Assisted Learning Center to Develop Student English Academic Writing Skills," *rEFlections* 28, no. 2 (2021): 147–67, <https://doi.org/10.61508/refl.v28i2.251147>.

²²⁸ Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

²²⁹ Bacon and De Guzman-Laddawan, "Engaging with Global Englishes through Peer-Assisted Learning: A Controlled Mixed-Methods Study of Burmese International Students as Peer Mentors at a Thai University."

²³⁰ Bacon and Torremucha, "Designing Cultural Bridges."

²³¹ Antal and Friedman, "Learning To Negotiate Reality."

therefore helps communicators consider how relationships, social roles, settings, and purposes influence an interaction²³².

Culture can influence how people think, what they expect, and how they communicate, but it does not decide everything about a person. People from the same culture can still be very different from each other²³³. Each person can have many identities, and these can change in different situations²³⁴. It is better to observe, ask questions, and stay open-minded than to make quick judgments about someone based on culture alone.

People from different backgrounds meet and talk in many places—at school, at work, while traveling, with family and friends, and on the internet²³⁵. In Thailand, for example, people often meet others from ASEAN countries and other parts of Asia²³⁶. When talking face-to-face, people use words, voices, and gestures. With phones or computers, they might write, speak, or send pictures²³⁷. Sometimes, people misunderstand each other because they do not see or hear things the same way²³⁸.

Intercultural competence means knowing about other cultures, being open-minded, and having good communication skills²³⁹. People who are curious, show respect, listen well, and can adjust their behavior are better at understanding others. It is normal to have misunderstandings sometimes. Good communicators try to clear things up, consider different points of view, and adjust how they speak or act as needed.

PAL gives students a place to work together, discuss ideas, and reflect on what they learn. In a university PAL center, students can talk with classmates, work on problems together, and get feedback right away²⁴⁰. By meeting regularly and building relationships, students can gradually improve their understanding of people from different backgrounds²⁴¹.

KEY TERMS

Communication: The process through which people create, exchange, and interpret meaning by using verbal and nonverbal messages.

Culture: The learned, shared, dynamic, and diverse ways through which groups understand the world and organize social life.

²³² Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

²³³ Dasli, "Reviving the 'Moments.'"

²³⁴ Kim, "Intercultural Personhood."

²³⁵ Arasaratnam and Doerfel, "Intercultural Communication Competence."

²³⁶ Pongsin et al., "Thailand as a New International Higher Education Hub."

²³⁷ Dooly, "Crossing the Intercultural Borders into 3rd Space Culture(s)."

²³⁸ Romero-Trillo and Lenn, "Do You '(Mis)Understand' What I Mean?"

²³⁹ Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

²⁴⁰ Bacon et al., "Integrating Seamless Learning within a Peer-Assisted Learning Center to Develop Student English Academic Writing Skills."

²⁴¹ Holmes and O'Neill, "Developing and Evaluating Intercultural Competence."

Identity: A person's understanding of who they are and how they relate to other people and social groups.

Context: The setting and conditions surrounding communication, including relationships, social roles, purpose, previous events, and expectations.

Intercultural communication: Communication among people who perceive meaningful cultural differences and must create and interpret meaning across those differences.

Globalization: The growing connection among countries, economies, institutions, and people through travel, migration, education, employment, trade, and technology.

Cultural diversity: The presence of different cultural, linguistic, ethnic, religious, and social backgrounds within a group, institution, or society.

Intercultural competence: The knowledge, attitudes, skills, and critical awareness needed to communicate effectively, appropriately, ethically, and respectfully across cultural differences.

Stereotype: A simplified belief that members of a group share the same characteristics, without sufficient attention to individual or situational differences.

Peer-Assisted Learning: A structured approach in which students support one another's learning through interaction, cooperation, and reflection. It can include peer mentoring between students from different cultural or linguistic backgrounds.

REVIEW AND DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

1. How are communication, culture, identity, and context connected during an intercultural encounter?
2. What is the difference among intracultural, cross-cultural, and intercultural communication? Give one example of each.
3. Why should culture be understood as learned, shared, dynamic, and diverse rather than fixed?
4. How can a person's multiple identities influence the way they communicate in different situations?
5. How has globalization increased opportunities and challenges for intercultural communication in universities, workplaces, travel, and everyday life?
6. Why should Thailand and ASEAN not be treated as having one uniform culture?
7. How can differences in language, tone, gestures, silence, or physical distance cause misunderstandings during face-to-face communication?
8. What challenges may occur during digital intercultural communication, and how can people communicate responsibly and respectfully online?
9. Which attitudes and skills are needed for intercultural competence, and which of these would you most like to develop?
10. How can you participate respectfully and effectively at Rangsit University's PAL center, support students from different linguistic and cultural backgrounds, and learn from the experience?

HOMEWORK: INTERCULTURAL STARTING POINT

This homework has three parts. It will help you examine your current intercultural competence, review the main ideas from Chapter 1, and prepare for intercultural learning at RSU's PAL center.

Part A: Initial Intercultural Competence Self-Assessment

Complete the intercultural competence self-assessment individually. Answer each item honestly according to your present knowledge, attitudes, skills, and awareness. The assessment is not a test, and there are no perfect answers. Its purpose is to help you recognize your current strengths and identify areas that you would like to develop. After completing it, establish one personal goal for this course and your peer-mentoring experience at RSU's PAL center. Your goal should describe a specific intercultural ability that you want to improve.

Part B: Group PowerPoint Presentation

Form a small group and select one principal topic from Chapter 1. Possible areas include communication and culture, culture and identity, contemporary intercultural communication, Thailand and ASEAN, university or workplace communication, travel and everyday life, face-to-face and digital encounters, intercultural competence, ethical communication, or learning through peer mentoring.

Prepare a PowerPoint presentation that explains your selected topic clearly and connects it to Chapter 1. Include at least one relevant real-world example and briefly analyze an intercultural encounter or misunderstanding. Explain how the participants could communicate more effectively, appropriately, ethically, and respectfully. Every group member must help prepare the presentation and have a meaningful speaking role.

Part C: Presentation in the Next Class

Your group will deliver its PowerPoint presentation at the beginning of the next class. All members must attend and participate. Listen respectfully to the other groups and consider how their topics connect to your own. These presentations will review the key ideas from Chapter 1 and prepare the class for the next chapter.

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